3:59 AM

By Marco Ramirez

LAZ: **(Pgs 532-547)** *(age 19 – speaks to audience)* It's like a hundred degrees outside, and every time I close my eyes I feel the walls ***closing*** in on me in my room.

'Cause it's just ***me*** in there now.

(My sister moved out like two weeks ago

And we don't know where she is)

Even though it's just ***me***, I swear to god the place is getting smaller.

And my aunt is coloring her hair,

And my mom is smoking cigarettes in the kitchen,

Screaming how I'm just like my father.

But I just ***go***.

I leave the apartment in my flip-flops and my gym shorts and my Field Day T-shirt from the sixth grade that still fits me 'cause I was fat

I just **go**. And even though it's a hundred degrees outside, I still gotta warm up my Civic. Keys in ignition. *(Pause while engine warms)*

And for a minute or two I just listen to that Honda engine put-put in Japanese . . . It comes to life, and I start driving.

And I don't remember putting my foot to the pedal

Or first gear . . . Or second gear . . . Or stoplights . . . But I'm gone.

. . . I fly.

And next thing I know I'm down a half a tank of gas

And I look at the clock, and bro,

TOGETHER: It's two o'clock

LAZ: In the morning.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR PLAYING HECTOR: *It's summer in the city, and Laz and Hector are both on the run from something they can't quite name. Maybe the sudden need for speed has something to do with Laz's sister, who took off two weeks ago, or with Hector's wife, who just called from the hospital. Join us for this late-night portrait of two young men tearing up the open road - and themselves. It's . . .*
TOGETHER*: 3:59 AM by Marco Ramirez*

HECTOR: *(Late 20s – speaks to audience)* And my manager's being a dick.

And not just because all managers are dicks pretty much always,

I mean, tonight he's being like a ***remarkable*** dick,

So I wave to him all nice on my way out of my job

And I take out my keys and I take out my cell phone on my way to the car-

I am SO tired . . . SO hungry

And I didn't wanna work a second shift today but my wife's three months pregnant

So that means I'm working a third and a fourth shift if I have to,

I know it's two o'clock in the morning, but I call her anyway just to let her know I'm on my way,

And she picks up fast like the phone was already in her hand.

And the first thing she says is "How was work."

But she's not asking . . . She's stalling.

And there's this silence. . .

There's this silence but I hear monitors and machines in the background.

And I'm like "What?"

And she tells me she didn't want me to worry.

Three· months pregnant,

She didn't see the ***point*** in bothering me at work.

LAZ: But that doesn't even matter --

HECTOR: And that's when she tells me we lost him.

And ten minutes later my sleeves are covered with tears and snot.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Twenty minutes later my knuckles are scraped and dented from punching the dashboard.

Window's fogged . . . Empty parking lot.

LAZ: *(Quiet)* It's just ***me*** in there now.

HECTOR: And I'm getting calls from the hospital but I can't pick up.

LAZ: *(Quiet)* . . . Just *me.*

HECTOR: And this is the point where I realize I've memorized the geography of my Subaru:

(He takes a quick inventory) Dashboard, Turn-signal, Scooby Doo steering wheel.

It was familiar before, but now I got all of it memorized.

And I know I ***should*** . . . I know it should be the first thing I do,

But something tells me I can't see her . . . I can't.

Not 'cause of her . . . 'Cause of me.

'Cause I'm just not strong enough.

So I start the car-

LAZ: - And I don't remember putting my foot to the pedal

HECTOR: - I start that car-

LAZ: - I don't remember first gear or second gear

HECTOR: - And I just go-

LAZ: - And I'm not thinking about my sister,

Or the look on her face when she left,

Or how weird it is to sleep in that room,

Or the fact that I prayed

-- Me: the loser of all losers

To make sure she was all right.

And I'm not thinking about how I should call her

Even though my mom told me if I did I'd be a traitor and an

embarrassment to the family

And I'm like "The Family?"

HECTOR: - The seat belt light is still on with this annoying chime thing that goes ding if you

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

don't put it on and I'm normally real safe about everything but not tonight -

LAZ: - And I turn on the radio-

HECTOR: - Tonight I don't -

LAZ: - And it's the late-night DJs that are like not good enough for regular radio . . .

HECTOR: And the streetlights are getting dimmer

LAZ: - And it's one -

HECTOR: - After another -

LAZ: - After another -

HECTOR: - Streetlights -

LAZ: - And eventually I just settle on static

HECTOR: - I don't even know where I'm going

LAZ: - Static -

HECTOR: - I'm the kinda guy who makes his parents recycle and here I am just eating up gas

streetlight after streetlight 'cause driving is just-

LAZ: - Nice with the static all up and every streetlight is like something I never seen before!-

HECTOR: - And for no reason in particular at one point in my driving,

In my whatever-I'm-doing, I slam on the brakes,

Put it in park. *(A beat)*

LAZ: And put the car in park.

HECTOR: And I look at my watch and-

LAZ: - It's three fifty-eight AM and I dunno where the hell I am.

HECTOR: But I don't care. *(A beat)*

LAZ: Wherever it is I've driven, everything looks like

HECTOR: - pitch-black-

LAZ: - Except a thin trail of moonlight tracing over

HECTOR: - A couple buildings in the background –

. . . And normally there's someone on the street

Even this late, right?

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Normally there's at least a cop car or a crackhead

But right now there's -

LAZ: - Nothing.

HECTOR: And I hear this stupid put-put sound coming from a car next to me.

LAZ: And in the middle of all the dark I look up and there's this [guy] I never seen before.

HECTOR: And it's just us and our steering wheels.

LAZ: And he looks me in the eyes like we're friends or [something] -

HECTOR: - Cowboys

LAZ: - In the eyes

HECTOR: - Showdown

LAZ: - Like we're friends.

HECTOR: . . . And I rev the engine

LAZ: - Oh yeah?

HECTOR: - And, you have to understand: I've never "revved" the engine before,

LAZ: - Like he's some kinda hot s*** in his Subaru . . . So I do the same-

HECTOR: *(building)* - And it's just me and this guy I don't know-

LAZ: - And everything is pitch-black except his headlights

HECTOR: - And I have NO idea where we are,

We're in some part of the city they don't even put on maps-

LAZ: - Come on-

HECTOR: - And am I really about to race someone?

LAZ: - Come on, yo -

HECTOR: - Ohmygod-

LAZ: - COME ON-

HECTOR: - And I dunno what the hell got into me but I just go-

LAZ: - And I don't even remember putting my foot to the pedal-

HECTOR: - Or first gear

LAZ: - Or second gear

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

HECTOR: - Or third gear **LAZ:** - Or fourth-

HECTOR: - Or stoplights-

LAZ: - But it's three fifty-nine AM and we're gone - *(building)*

HECTOR: - Holy s***- **LAZ:** - And next thing I know I'm going eighty

HECTOR: - Ninety-

LAZ: - Ninety-five miles an hour down a stretch of road that's empty, that nobody's been on for like a hundred years-

HECTOR: - I fly- **LAZ:** - Hundred miles an hour, the road curves

HECTOR: - I curve with it-

LAZ: - Hundred-ten he catches up. And at a hundred-twenty I'm about to max out but I don't even care-

HECTOR: - I'm going a hundred-thirty miles an hour like some kind of moron-

LAZ: - HOLY S***-

HECTOR: - THE SPEEDOMETER ISN'T EVEN CLOCKING HOW FAST I'M GOING ANYMORE WHAT THE HELL AM I DOING-

LAZ: - AND I AM NOT THINKING ABOUT MY SISTER-

HECTOR: - AND SUDDENLY ALL THE DARKNESS AROUND US BECOMES LIKE SOMETHING, ELSE-

LAZ: - OUTTA NOWHERE THERE'S MAD STREAKS OF LIGHT JUST STREAMING ACROSS THE WINDSHIELD LIKE LIGHT WAS MADE INTO WATER AND IT'S RAINING BRO-

HECTOR: - IT'S RAINING LIGHT BUT AT THIS POINT I'M EVEN SCARED TO SLOW DOWN - AND OUTTA NOWHERE THERE ARE THESE-

LAZ: - STARS SCRAPING AGAINST MY WINDSHIELD AND. I MOVE TO PUT THE WIPERS BUT I CAN'T 'CAUSE-

HECTOR: - THERE'S LIKE A G-FORCE HOLDING ME BACK AND I CAN'T MOVE -

LAZ: - LIKE ON A ROLLERCOASTER

HECTOR: - LIKE IN SPACE- AND AT THIS POINT WE'RE NOT EVEN RACING AGAINST EACH OTHER-

LAZ: - AT THIS POINT I'M LOOKIN' THROUGH THE WINDOW AND I COULD SEE THE SIDES OF

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

THIS DUDE'S SUBARU ON FIRE BRO-

HECTOR: - AND THE STEERING WHEEL AND THE SCOOBY DOO COVER AND EVERYTHING START TORATTLE-

LAZ: - AND MY "PUT-PUT" BECOMES LIKE SHAKING-

HECTOR: - AND EVERY HINGE AND EVERY SCREW IN MY CAR FEELS LIKE IT'S ABOUT TO COME APART-

LAZ: - BUT JUST BEFORE IT DOES-

HECTOR: *(to himself)* - EVERYTHING'S ABOUT TO COME APART-

LAZ: - AAAAGH! -

HECTOR: - WHAT AM I DOING?! *(to himself)* - GROW UP-

LAZ: - JUST JUST JUST-

HECTOR: - MAN UP!! -

LAZ: - JUST BEFORE LIKE ALL OF IT

HECTOR: - EXPLODES, I HEAR-

LAZ: - NOTHING. *(a beat. Silence. Just silence)*

HECTOR: And there's this moment. . . This moment of . . .

LAZ: . . . nothing. *(a beat. Then softer . . .)*

HECTOR: And through the flames and the light and the dark and the shaking and the speed I see-

LAZ: - Pitch-black. *(silence)*

HECTOR: And when I wake up, my car is in the middle of an intersection.

LAZ: Streetlight, puddle, garbage cans, payphone,just . . .

HECTOR: An intersection. And I'm in one piece. And so's he.

LAZ: Yup. *(shock)*

HECTOR: And now everything's-

LAZ: - Normal.

HECTOR: . . . My tank's almost empty,

LAZ: And my engine's back to put-putting,

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

HECTOR: And I lean out my window and I can see there's a streak like a bum-mark on the side of my car, but other than that-

LAZ: - We're alive. *(for the first time, they look at each other; a beat)*

HECTOR: And I look at this guy and I dunno what to say

LAZ: - And neither does he -

HECTOR: - But he shoots me this little head-nod like *(LAZ shoots him an alpha-male head-nod) (a beat)* And that's enough. (a beat; something's changed) And I turn the key in.the ignition

LAZ: Put-put. Put-put.

HECTOR: Dashboard, Turn-signal, Scooby Doo steering wheel.

LAZ: Like normal.

HECTOR: And I put my seatbelt on.

LAZ: It's 3:59 in the morning. Still. And I don't know where the hell I am -

HECTOR: - But I got somewhere I need to go. *(light out on HECTOR. LAZ looks around, taking inventory)*

LAZ: Streetlight. Puddle. Garbage can. Payphone . . . Payphone.

And now I'm outta my car.

And now I'm picking up the headset.

Now I'm outta my car,

And my sister gets a call.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Marco Ramirez
Book: Plays for Two, Pgs 532-547
ISBN: 978-0345804549
Publisher: Vintage Books
Date (Month/Year): Mar 2014

AWARD HISTORY

2025 National Qualifier
NIETOC

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY